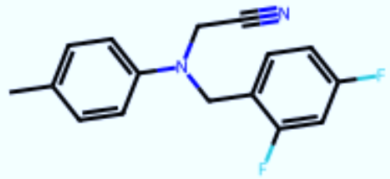
	Smiles	Standard Type	Standard Relation	Standard Value	Standard Units	Assay ChEMBL ID	ROMol
						EMBL3625335	
	@H]1CC[C@@H]2CN1C(=O)N2OS(=O)(=O)[O-].[Na+]	MIC	'<='	0.120	ug.mL-1	CHEMBL5247824	

DSA103 Advanced Chemical Data Science

Lecture 12: Life Science Data – Data Structures / Molecular Representations

Dr. Johannes Schörgenhumer (johannes.schoergenhumer@chem.uzh.ch)

Motivation

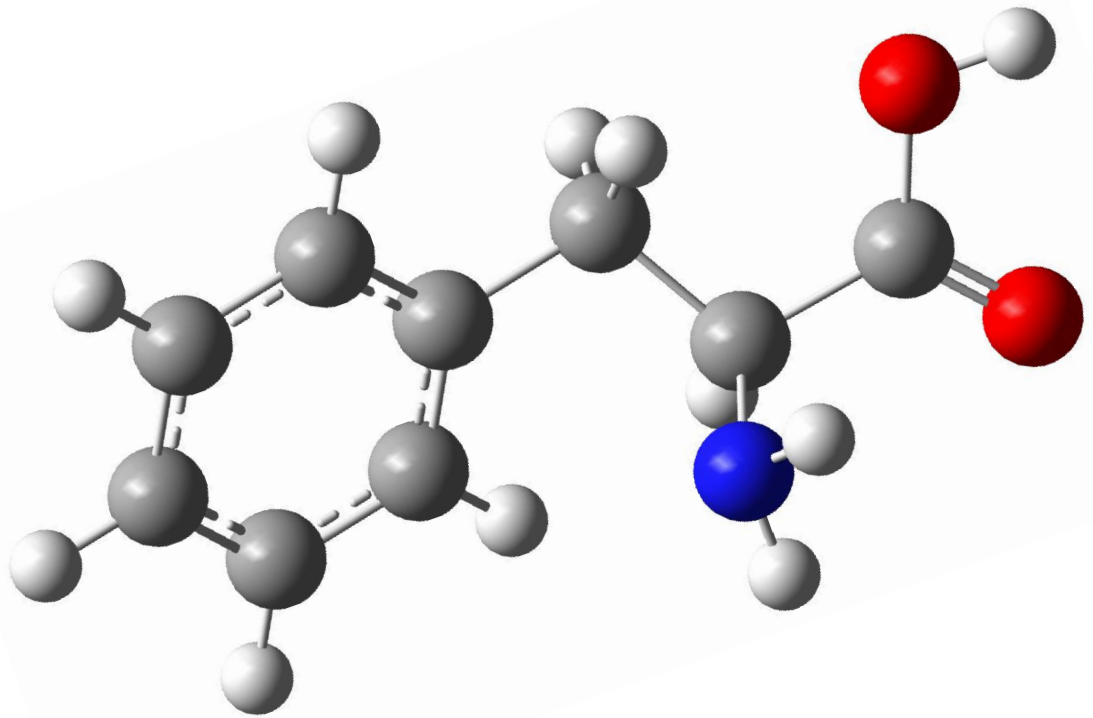
Data Structures: How data types are actually encoded, as strings, matrixes, coordinate lists, ...

Today we look again at molecular representations!

Representations translate chemistry into data!

Different means (e.g. 1D, 2D, 3D, fingerprints, reactions)…

…for different tasks (e.g. property prediction, structure search)



Content overview

Chemical Notations:

- SMILES
- Bit vectors / Fingerprints

Mathematical Notations:

- Graphs
- Matrices
- Connection tables

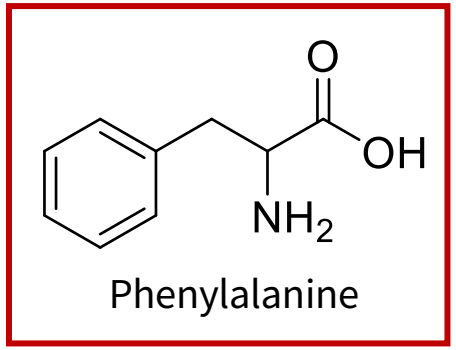
3D representations and some data formats

Encoding chemical reactions

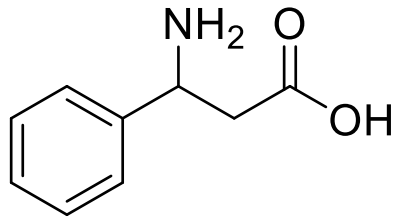
Encoding molecular structures – SMILES:

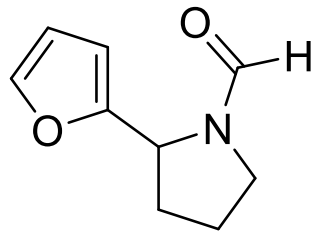
1D chemical notations:

Empirical formula / “Sum formula”: e.g. $C_9H_{11}NO_2$



Phenylalanine





SMILES: NC(Cc1ccccc1)C(O)=O
Or: C1=CC=C(C=C1)C[C@@H](C(=O)O)N
Or: NC(C(=O)O)(CC1=CC=CC=C1)

SLN (SYBYL Line Notation): C[1]H:CH:CH:CH:CH:C(:@1)CH2CH(NH2)C(=O)OH

InChI (IUPAC International Chemical Identifier): 1S/C9H11NO2/c10-8(9(11)12)6-7-4-2-1-3-5-7/h1-5,8H,6,10H2,(H,11,12)/t8-/m0/s1

- Normalized (aromaticity, tautomers)
- Canonicalized (unambigous labelling)
- Serialized (linear string as output)

Chemical formula | Connection sublayer | H atom sublayer | stereochemistry

InChIKey: Compressed, not human-interpretable 27 character string computed from InChI for facilitated search, e.g. Phenylalanine = COLNVLDHVKWLRT-QMMMGPOBSA-N

Engel T. (2018) *Principles of Molecular Representations* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 9-41), Wiley-VCH.

Encoding molecular structures – SMARTS: SMILES as a query language

Every atom and bond becomes a pattern to search for substructures, not whole molecules

Pattern	Matches
`[#6]`	any carbon, aliphatic or aromatic
`C / c`	aliphatic / aromatic carbon only
`[NX3;H1,H2]`	N with 3 connections and 1 or 2 H
`[C,N;!R]`	C or N (comma = OR), not in a ring
`* and ~`	any atom and any bond
`C@C`	ring bond between two aliphatic C

```
patt = Chem.MolFromSmarts(
   '[CX3](=O)[OX2H1]')
mol.HasSubstructMatch(patt)
mol.GetSubstructMatches(patt)
```

Careful

Any SMILES is valid SMARTS, but the meaning shifts: C now matches in SMILES is an aliphatic carbon, whatever its hydrogens. Always parse queries with MolFromSmarts, never MolFromSmiles.

https://www.daylight.com/dayhtml/doc/theory/theory.smarts.html

Acitivity: SMARTS Exercises

1) Quick demo
2) Follow the notebook smarts_exercises.ipynb

Encoding molecular structures – Bit Vectors / Fingerprints:

Bit vectors: “Barcode” for molecular structure:

- Boolean array, sequence of bits (e.g. based on structural features)
- Linear binary strings of fixed length
- Fast to compute
- “One-way” encoding

As bit vectors, structure can be encoded into:

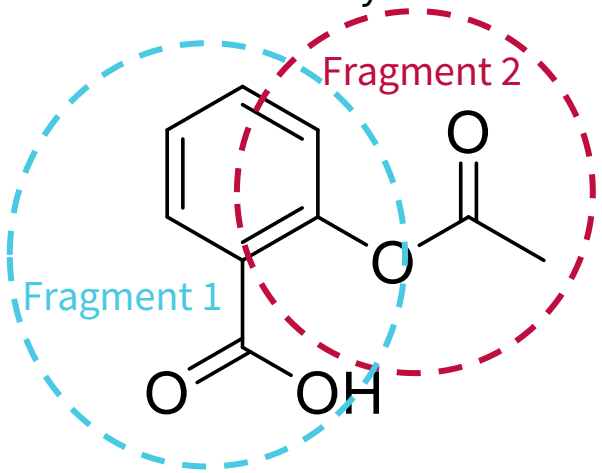
- Hash codes: typically 64-bit vectors, easily indexed, for storing data and searching (full structures)
- **Structure keys:** Boolean vector, encoding structural features based on predefined fragment diary (“contains N”, “contains rings”, …), e.g. MACCS
- **Fingerprints:** No fragment dictionaries. Algorithm generates a series of patterns (atoms / bond sequences), and generates bit vectors for them (e.g. Morgan)

Fingerprints / Structure keys can be used as descriptors in substructure searches, clustering, similarity assessment (e.g. **Tanimoto similarity**)

Tomczak J. (2018) *Data Types* In Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 156-168), Wiley-VCH.

Feature engineering: fingerprints

Encode structure as binary vector!



	Amine	Aromatic ring	Carbonyl	Hydroxy
Fragment 1	0	1	1	1
Fragment 2	0	1	1	0

Extended-Connectivity Fingerprints (ECFP / Morgan fingerprints):

— Local neighborhoods hashed into bit vectors

— Typically: 1024 or 2048 bits

— Well-suited for capturing structural information

— Widely applied in QSAR studies

Fingerprint generators in RDKit:
— **AtomPairFP** = rdkit.Chem.rdFingerprintGenerator.FPType.AtomPairFP
— **MorganFP** = rdkit.Chem.rdFingerprintGenerator.FPType.MorganFP
— **RDKitFP** = rdkit.Chem.rdFingerprintGenerator.FPType.RDKitFP
— **TopologicalTorsionFP** = rdkit.Chem.rdFingerprintGenerator.FPType.TopologicalTorsionFP

https://www.rdkit.org/docs/source/rdkit.Chem.rdFingerprintGenerator.html

Acitivity: Calculate fingerprints and assess similarity

1) Use the Morgan fingerprint generator in rdkit to create bit vectors for two molecules (SMILES)
2) Assess the similarity of the two molecules using the fingerprint to calculate a **Tanimoto score**
3) Try different fingerprint generators and see how the similarity score changes

Note: There are a few fingerprint generators available in rdkit (see link below):

- Morgan
- Feature Morgan (variation of the Morgan fingerprint)
- RDKit
- Atom pairs
- Topological torsions

https://greglandrum.github.io/rdkit-blog/posts/2023-01-18-fingerprint-generator-tutorial.html

@Tanimoto similarity = similarity of binary vectors (not only "how alike are two molecules?")

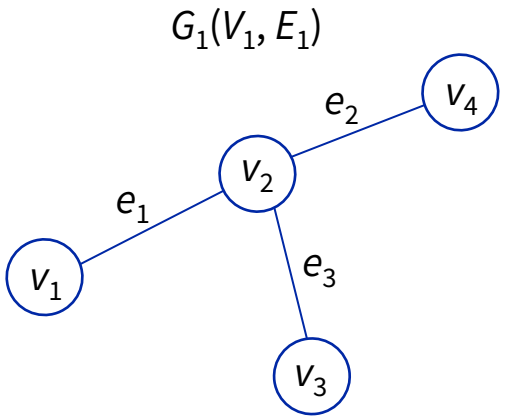
Very dependent on the fingerprint type / binary vector and on the applications:

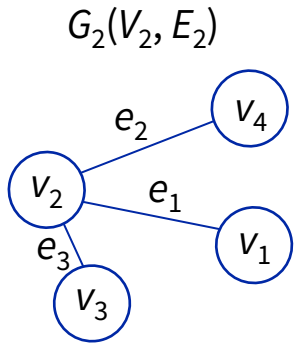
- **≥ 0.85 (Daylight fingerprints):** the classic "similar bioactivity" cutoff. Studies later showed it is far less reliable than its reputation, since a substantial share of pairs above it differ in activity.
- **≈ 0.4 to 0.5 (ECFP4/Morgan r=2):** often cited as the equivalent of 0.85 for Daylight. ECFP scores run lower, so the same cutoff would be much too strict.
- **≥ 0.9 (PubChem fingerprints):** the cutoff PubChem uses for its "similar compounds" neighbours.
- **≈ 0.7 to 0.8 (ECFP4):** usually treated as "close analogs", often single-substituent changes, and used to flag near-duplicates.

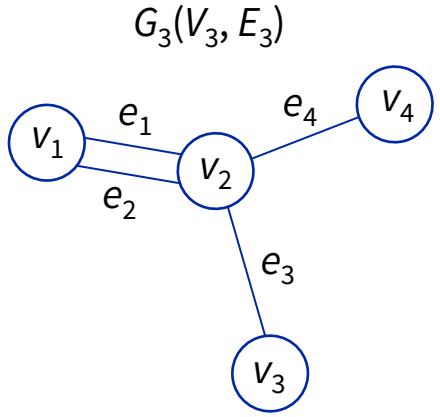
Mathematical Notations

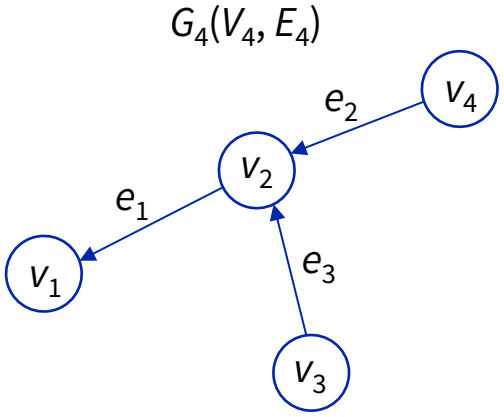
Graphs:

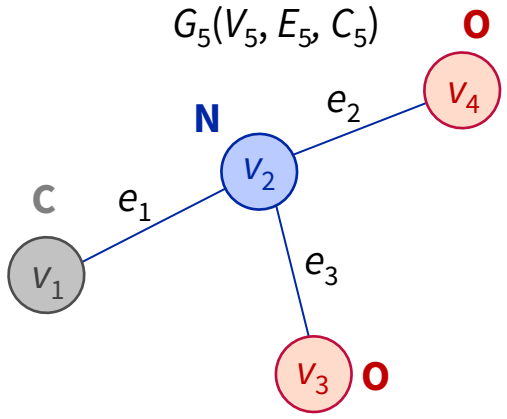
- Structures can be imagined as graphs
- Graph = tuple of vertices & edges: $G = (V, E)$
- "Vertices v_1 and v_1 are *adjacent* if *incident* in a common edge e_1"
- Graphs per se carry no 2D or 3D information ($G_1 = G_2$)
- *Multigraphs* have vertices connected by more than one edge
- *Directed graph* / *digraph*: edges are asymmetric
- Can be coded / coloured: $G = (V, E, C)$











Engel T. (2018) *Principles of Molecular Representation* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 9-42), Wiley-VCH.

Mathematical Notations

Matrices:

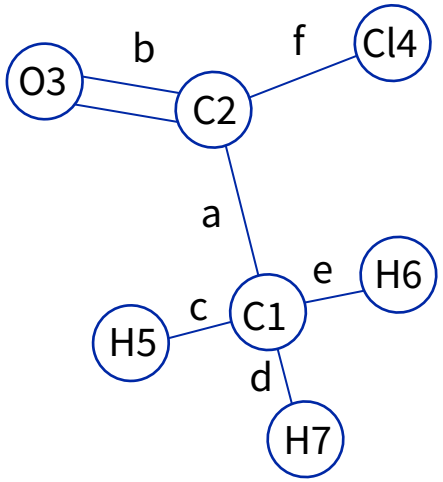
- Based on graphs
- Can be used as descriptors
- *Adjacency matrix*: represents the connectivity of all atoms
- *Distance matrix*: reflects bond lengths
- *Incidence matrix*: represents the relationships between atoms
- *Bond matrix*: reflects bonds and bond orders

$A_A =$

	C1	C2	O3	Cl4	H5	H6	H7
C1	0	1	0	0	1	1	1
C2	1	0	1	1	0	0	0
O3	0	1	0	0	0	0	0
Cl4	0	1	0	0	0	0	0
H5	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
H6	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
H7	1	0	0	0	0	0	0

=

	C1	C2	O3	Cl4
C1	0	1	0	0
C2	1	0	1	1
O3	0	1	0	0
Cl4	0	1	0	0



$A_I =$

	C1	C2	O3	Cl4	H5	H6	H7
a	1	1	0	0	0	0	0
b	0	1	1	0	0	0	0
c	1	0	0	0	1	0	0
d	1	0	0	0	0	1	0
e	1	0	0	0	0	0	1
f	0	1	0	1	0	0	0

$A_B =$

	C1	C2	O3	Cl4
C1	0	1	0	0
C2	1	0	2	1
O3	0	2	0	0
Cl4	0	1	0	0

Engel T. (2018) *Principles of Molecular Representation* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 9-42), Wiley-VCH.

Mathematical Notations

Connection tables:

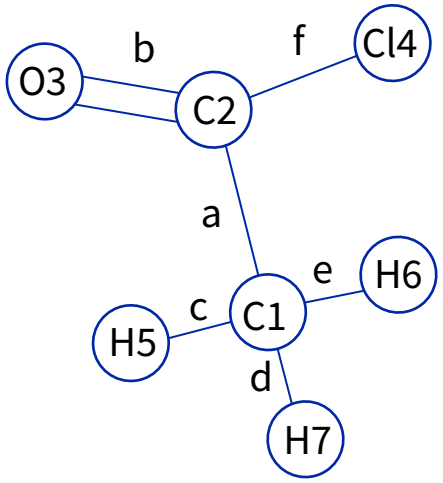
- Based on graphs
- Matrices contain a lot of redundant information
- Atoms are arbitrarily indexed
- Bonds listed with their bond order (BO)
- Atom and bond tables can be combined
- Hydrogens and redundant bond definitions can be omitted

Atom list

Atom index	Element
1	C
2	C
3	O
4	Cl
5	H
6	H
7	H

Bond list

1st atom index	2nd atom index	bond order
1	2	1
1	5	1
1	6	1
1	7	1
2	3	2
2	4	1



Atom index	Element	1st atom index	BO	2nd atom index	BO	3rd atom index	BO	4th atom index	BO
1	C	2	1	5	1	6	1	7	1
2	C	1	1	3	2	4	1		
3	O	2	2						
4	Cl	2	1						
5	H	1	1						
6	H	1	1						
7	H	1	1						

Atom index	Element	1st atom index	BO	2nd atom index	BO
1	C	2	1		
2	C	3	2	4	1
3	O				
4	Cl				

Engel T. (2018) *Principles of Molecular Representation* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 9-42), Wiley-VCH.

3D representations and some data formats

XYZ format

- Cartesian coordinates for all atoms given
- Constitution and configuration implicitly given
- Similarly encoded in a lot of other formats

```
7
acetylchloride
C    -6.666666    -1.461295     0.000000
C    -6.153324    -0.735339     1.257405
O    -6.454696     0.469394     1.460785
Cl    -5.141676    -1.593562     2.413961
H    -6.310012    -2.470105     0.000000
H    -6.309994    -0.956897    -0.873652
H    -7.736666    -1.461282     0.000000

```

Header with total number of atoms
Optional comment (line not optional!)

Table of cartesian coordinates. No Connection Table!

MOPAC format

- Z-matrix
- Basically, polar coordinates
- Constitution and configuration implicitly given
- Mostly used in QM and DFT suites (*internal coordinates*)

```

acetylchloride.mop

 C    0.000000  0    0.000000  0    0.000000  0    0   0   0
 C    1.540000  1    0.000000  0    0.000000  0    1   0   0
 O    1.258400  1  120.226946  1    0.000000  0    2   1   0
 Cl   1.760000  1  119.886527  1  179.999999  1    2   1   3
 H    1.070000  1  109.471203  1  179.999776  1    1   2   3
 H    1.070000  1  109.471251  1   59.999791  1    1   2   3
 H    1.070000  1  109.471218  1  299.999777  1    1   2   3

```

Note: Data formats often have a strictly defined syntax and can often only be processed if that syntax is followed to the letter!

Engel T. (2018) *Computer Processing of Chemical Structure Information* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 43-119), Wiley-VCH.

Acitivity: Data structures

1) Demo: Review different structure formats: .pdb, .mol, .mol2, .gjf

2) From a provided computational file (yne.gjf), use the connection data to derive the 2D structure of the molecule. What other data do you find in the file?

3) Discuss how you would be able to extract bond length for a specific atom pair from xyz-files.

To visualise 3D structures (and to build), you need software that can handle the structure formats, e.g.

- Chem3D
- Avogadro (https://avogadro.cc/)
- Jmol (https://jmol.sourceforge.net/)
- Pymol (https://pymol.org/)

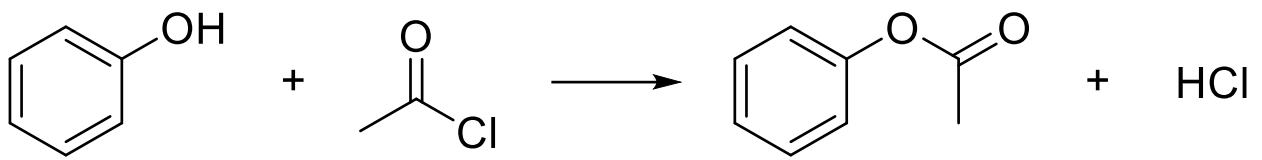
Encoding chemical reactions

Reaction = mapping between two molecular states / a transformation in chemical space.

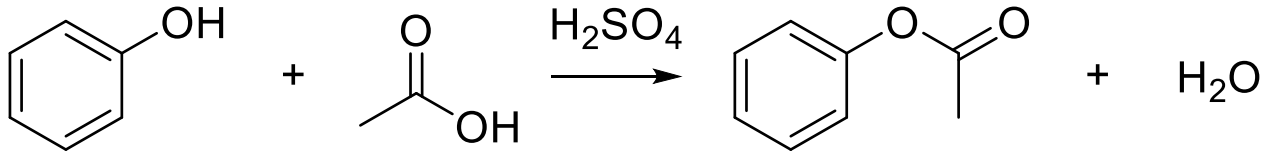
Reaction representations are important for **reaction prediction**, **classification**, and **retrosynthetic analysis**.

Representations:

1) Textual by components (columns)
2) Single string:
   - Reaction SMILES / SMARTS
   - RInChI (Layered string) / RInChIKey
3) Structured (e.g. arrays):
   - CML (similar to XML)
   - ORD Schema
4) Fingerprints
5) Graphs




```
"c1ccccc1cO.CC(=O)Cl >> c1ccccc1OC(=O)C.Cl"
```




```
"c1ccccc1cO.CC(=O)O > OS(=O)(=O)O > c1ccccc1OC(=O)C.O"
```


Sacher O., Gasteiger J. (2018) *Representation of Chemical Reactions* in Engel, T., Gasteiger, J., *Cheminformatics* (1st ed., pp. 121-154), Wiley-VCH.
https://greglandrum.github.io/rdkit-blog/posts/2025-06-12-using-reaction-info.html
https://deepwiki.com/rdkit/rdkit-tutorials/2.3-smarts-reactions
https://www.daylight.com/meetings/summerschool01/course/basics/smirks.html

Acitivity: Reaction encoding

1) Demo: How to work with a Reaction SMARTS in rdkit

2) Come up with SMARTS for these transformations:
   - Ester hydrolysis: C(=O)OR → C(=O)OH
   - Halogen exchange: Cl → Br
   - Bonus: Esterification R1OH + R2COOH → R2COOR1

3) What could these Reaction SMARTS be used for?

4) Continue with the SMARTS exercises